KPPSC PMS IR Master Notes — Q1: The Rise of China, Balance of Power & Multipolarity

KPPSC PMS • INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS (100 MARKS)
Master Model Solution & Theoretical Deconstruction | 20 Marks Master Answer Guide

Executive Examination Metadata

Parameter	Specification
Target Examination	KPPSC PMS (Provincial Management Service) — Khyber Pakhtunkhwa
Paper & Subject	International Relations (100 Marks Optional — Group 6)
EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED:	• **2025 Q.1:** "The rise of China is widely interpreted as a revival of balance of power politics, signaling a global shift toward multipolarity. Analyze the political, strategic and economic factors that are shaping the new international order. (20 Marks)" • **2022 Q.3:** "The trade war between the US and China has jeopardized the global economic order impacting all regions and states; Pakistan caught between these two global powers is likely to be affected the most. Analyze Pakistan's predicament and suggest policy options to safeguard its national security objectives. (20 Marks)" • **2022 Q.5:** "The Chinese Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) has global outreach in Asia, Africa, and Europe at the cost of US hegemony. Discuss its main objectives and analyze challenges and prospects of its success. (20 Marks)" • **2018 Q.6:** "There may be a possible trade war between the USA and China that would rattle certain American businesses and force consumers to pay more for products. Discuss the term \"trade war\" and elaborate on why Trump was targeting China. (20 Marks)"
Syllabus Section	Part A: Balance of Power & State System | Part C: Major Powers & Global Order
Question Allocation	Attempt 1 of 5 Required (20 Marks | Strict 35-Minute Allocation)
Historiographical / Theoretical Thesis	The rapid rise of China represents a classic structural power transition (Organski) that ends post-Cold War American unipolarity (Krauthammer) and revives balance-of-power imperatives. As offensive realism (Mearsheimer) predicts, China seeks regional hegemony in the Indo-Pacific while balancing US containment, generating a 'Thucydides Trap' (Allison). Rather than a simple bipolar confrontation, the emerging order is an asymmetric, multiplex multipolarity (Acharya) defined by geo-economic counter-balancing (BRI, BRICS, SCO) and strategic hedging across the Global South.

🎯 Exam Questions Linked

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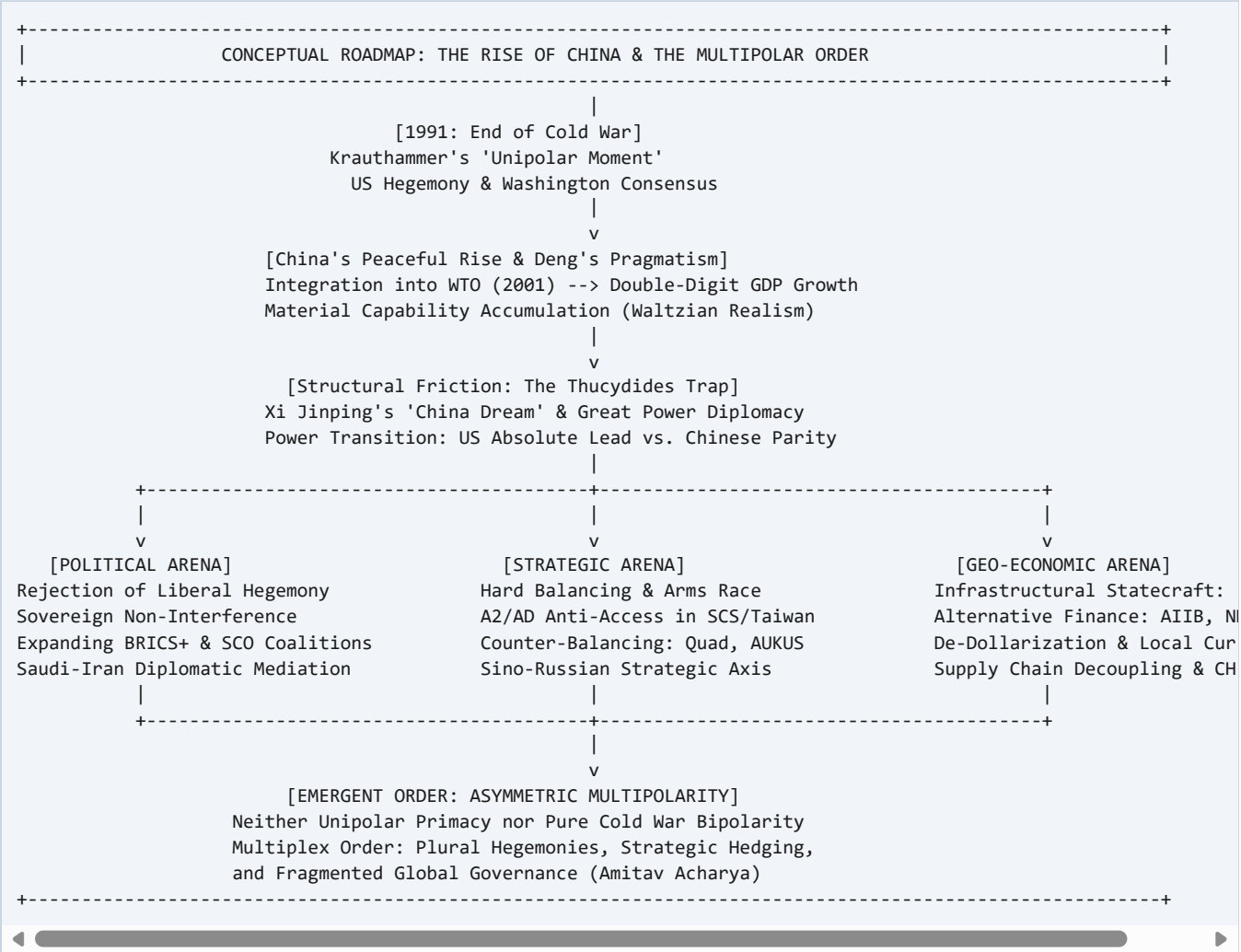
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Exam Essential Takeaways

• STRUCTURAL POWER TRANSITION: China's economic ascendance (overtaking US in PPP terms) has fundamentally shifted the material distribution of capabilities in the international system, triggering systemic balancing dynamics as posited by Kenneth Waltz's Neorealism.

> • BIPOLARITY AT THE CORE, MULTIPOLARITY AT THE PERIPHERY: While the military and technological frontier forms a dual US-China strategic rivalry, the global political economy is thoroughly multipolar—with the EU, India, Russia, and regional middle powers resisting binary bloc alignment.
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> • GEO-ECONOMIC & INSTITUTIONAL COUNTER-BALANCING: Unlike the USSR's ideological-military balancing, China combines hard-power modernisation (PLAN blue-water navy, A2/AD systems) with infrastructural diplomacy (Belt and Road Initiative) and alternative financial architecture (AIIB, CIPS, BRICS New Development Bank).
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> • EXAMINER WARNING: High scoring in KPPSC PMS requires grounding your analysis in core IR theories—explicitly contrasting John Mearsheimer's Offensive Realism, Graham Allison's Thucydides Trap, G. John Ikenberry's Liberal Order persistence, and Amitav Acharya's Multiplex World.

Conceptual Thematic Map & Strategic Roadmap



Analytical Dimensions & Systemic Shifts Matrix

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
Material Distribution of Power	China's GDP reaches ~$18T; defense modernization expands PLA Navy into the world's largest fleet by hull count.	Erosion of US absolute unipolar primacy; return of structural anarchy where power parity drives intense systemic balancing (Kenneth Waltz).
Indo-Pacific Strategic Architecture	US establishes Quad (US-India-Japan-Australia) & AUKUS; China consolidates A2/AD bubbles and South China Sea bases.	Regional security dilemma escalates; balance of threat (Walt) replaces global collective security with militarized containment rings.
Institutional Statecraft	Launch of AIIB (100+ members), expansion of BRICS (BRICS+), and consolidation of Shanghai	Soft-balancing against Western-dominated Bretton Woods institutions (IMF, World Bank), fostering non-

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
	Cooperation Organization (SCO).	Western diplomatic convergence.
Geo-economics & Trade Wars	Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) connects 150+ nations; US responds with tariffs, export controls (CHIPS Act), and 'de-risking'.	Weaponized interdependence (Drezner/Farrell); fragmentation of global trade into competing techno-economic ecosystems.
Diplomatic Norms & Mediation	Beijing-brokered Saudi-Iran Normalization (2023); Global Security Initiative (GSI) promoting sovereign non-interference.	Challenging Western liberal interventionism; legitimizing a pluralistic, Westphalian-sovereigntist model of conflict management.

The 20-Mark Master Model Essay (~650-700 Words)

Introduction: The Demise of Unipolarity and the Return of Structural Balancing

The contemporary international order is undergoing the most profound structural realignment since the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991. The post-Cold War era, famously characterized by Charles Krauthammer as the 'unipolar moment,' was defined by uncontested American military primacy, the global diffusion of neo-liberal economics under the Washington Consensus, and the perceived universality of Western institutionalism. However, the meteoric economic, technological, and military ascension of the People's Republic of China (PRC) has conclusively terminated this unipolar interregnum. Through the prism of structural realism, as articulated by Kenneth Waltz, changes in the international system are fundamentally dictated by shifts in the distribution of material capabilities across major powers. China's emergence as the world's second-largest economy—and the largest in Purchasing Power Parity (PPP)—has revived balance-of-power politics as the cardinal operating principle of global affairs. Rather than conforming to Francis Fukuyama's vision of liberal ideological convergence, global politics has entered a phase of intense systemic competition where China's bid for regional hegemony directly collides with American determination to preserve its global primacy, propelling the international system toward an asymmetric, multiplex multipolarity.

Political Drivers: Ideational Pluralism, Sovereignty, and Counter-Hegemonic Coalitions

Politically, the rise of China has fractured the normative consensus of the US-led liberal international order. Beijing champions a rigorous defense of traditional Westphalian sovereignty, explicitly repudiating Western liberal doctrines of conditional sovereignty, democratic interventionism, and human rights conditionality. Through diplomatic frameworks such as the Global Security Initiative (GSI) and the Global Development Initiative (GDI), China promotes a model of 'sovereign pluralism' that resonates powerfully across the Global South. Furthermore, Beijing has systematically spearheaded the institutional expansion of counter-hegemonic platforms—most notably the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) and the expanded BRICS+ grouping. By providing non-Western powers with credible institutional venues that operate independently of G7 oversight, China has facilitated political balancing against Western hegemony. This diplomatic clout was demonstrated by the historic, Beijing-brokered Saudi-Iran rapprochement in March 2023, signaling China's emergence as a premier diplomatic arbiter capable of re-engineering strategic geometries in regions historically dominated by Western security umbrellas.

Strategic and Military Dynamics: Hard Balancing, Security Dilemmas, and the Indo-Pacific Pivot

Strategically, the international system is witnessing a severe escalation of the security dilemma, particularly across the maritime commons of the Indo-Pacific. In his seminal text The Tragedy of Great Power Politics, John Mearsheimer posits under offensive structural realism that great powers inherently seek to maximize their share of world power, with the ultimate objective of achieving regional hegemony while denying it to rival peers. In accordance with this logic, China has developed formidable Anti-Access/Area-Denial (A2/AD) capabilities—spanning hypersonic glide vehicles, advanced submarine warfare, and militarized island outposts in the South China Sea—designed to push American carrier strike groups beyond the First and Second Island Chains. In response, the United States has enacted classic external balancing strategies, reinvigorating the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) with India, Japan, and Australia, and establishing the AUKUS security pact with Britain and Australia. The strategic flashpoint of Taiwan epitomizes Graham Allison's 'Thucydides Trap': a rising power threatening to displace an established hegemon, generating structural friction where miscalculation could precipitate systemic conflagration.

Economic and Geo-economic Realities: Weaponized Interdependence and Parallel Financial Architectures

Economically, balance-of-power politics has migrated from territorial conquest to geo-economic statecraft and the weaponization of interdependence. The Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), encompassing over a trillion dollars in

transcontinental infrastructure, represents an unprecedented exercise in structural statecraft, physically reorienting Eurasian and African trade corridors toward Beijing. Simultaneously, recognizing vulnerability to US financial hegemony—manifested in the extraterritorial application of SWIFT sanctions against Russia—China has pioneered alternative institutional and financial clearing architecture. Initiatives such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), the New Development Bank (NDB), and the Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS), coupled with bilateral local-currency trade settlements (petroyuan accords), represent deliberate soft-balancing against Bretton Woods dominance. While Washington pursues economic 'de-risking,' export restrictions on advanced semiconductors (the CHIPS Act), and tariff barriers, the reality of deep commercial entanglement ensures that global balancing remains economically fragmented rather than strictly bifurcated.

Conclusion: The Contours of an Asymmetric, Multiplex International Order

In conclusion, the rise of China has undeniably catalyzed the revival of balance of power politics, definitively dismantling the unipolar architecture of the post-Cold War world. However, the emergent international order does not represent a simplistic replica of twentieth-century Cold War bipolarity. Because globalized supply chains and multilateral interdependencies persist, the international system is evolving into what Amitav Acharya terms a 'multiplex world'—a decentered, asymmetric multipolarity where the US and China form the principal strategic poles, yet regional middle powers (such as India, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and Brazil) exercise unprecedented strategic autonomy through multi-alignment and hedging. Ultimately, the stability of this new order will depend on whether the reigning hegemon and the ascending challenger can establish mutual strategic reassurance, managing their balance of power without succumbing to the cataclysmic systemic conflict historically associated with power transitions.

Theoretical Perspectives & Quotable Thesis Arguments

Theorist / Scholar	Theoretical School	Exact Quotable Thesis Argument
John J. Mearsheimer	*Offensive Structural Realism*	"A wealthy China will not be a status quo power; it will try to dominate Asia the way the United States dominates the Western Hemisphere. The result will be an intense security competition with a high probability of war."
Graham Allison	*Power Transition Theory*	"The defining question of global order for our time is whether China and the United States can escape Thucydides's Trap: when a rising power threatens to displace a ruling power, resulting structural stress makes violent clash the rule, not the exception."
Kenneth N. Waltz	*Neorealism / Structural Realism*	"In an anarchic order, balance of power is not a policy choice but an inevitable systemic outcome; whenever power asymmetries emerge, other states will balance to ensure their survival."
G. John Ikenberry	*Liberal Institutionalism*	"The rise of China does not have to trigger the demise of the Western order. The modern international order is unusually dense, institutionalized, and open—making it easy to join and hard to overturn."
Amitav Acharya	*Constructivist / Post-Western IR*	"The emerging global architecture is not a unipolar hegemony, nor a new Cold War bipolarity, but a 'multiplex world'—like a cinema with multiple screens showing different movies, where diverse actors shape order across overlapping issue areas."